THE INVISIBLE HALF

Rwanda records almost every birth, but only half of its deaths · Vital statistics 2019–2025

92.9%

of births were recorded in 2025



50.5%

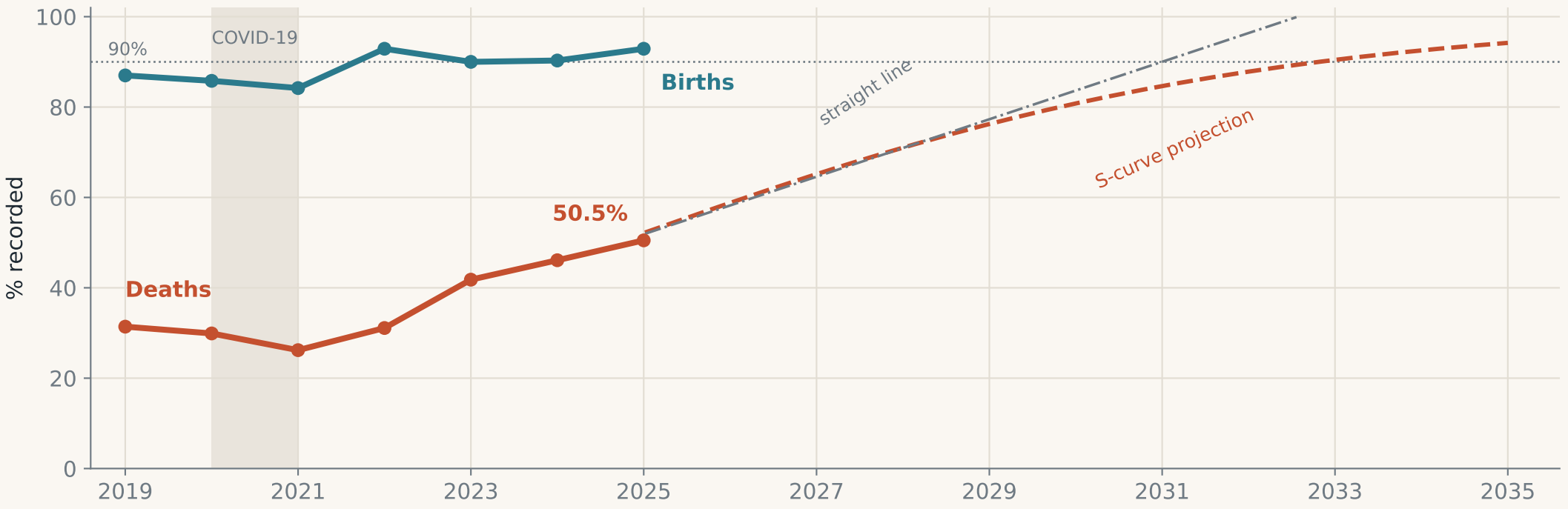
of deaths were recorded in 2025



38,521 deaths went unrecorded in 2025: about 106 every day.

1 The gap is closing, fast

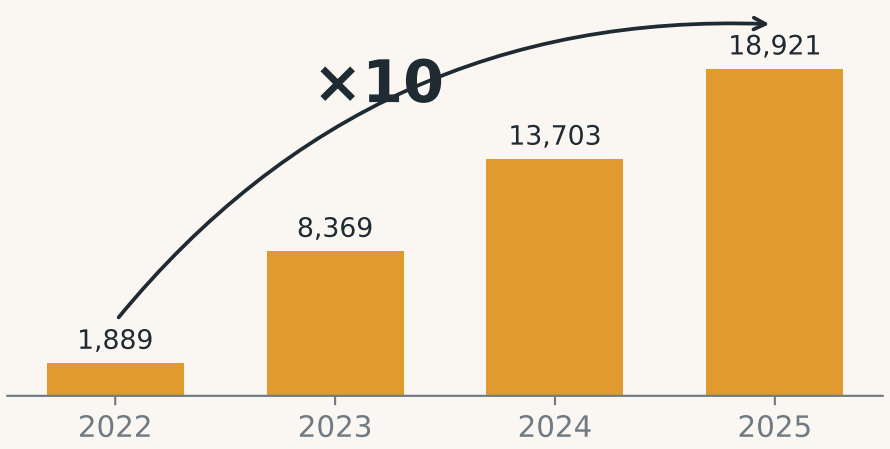
Deaths recorded rose from 26% (2021) to 50.5% (2025). If this pace continues, 90% would be recorded by about 2031 (straight line) to 2033 (S-curve, fitted by gradient descent).



Rwanda is now at the steepest point of the curve (50%): gains will come more slowly from here.

2 What changed?

Verbal autopsies (family interviews about deaths outside health facilities) grew tenfold.



This coincided with the 2022–25 rise in recorded deaths. Old deaths are being registered too: 328 → 14,517 deaths registered over a year late (2022 → 2025).

3 Women's deaths are counted less

Out of every 10 deaths in 2025, recorded:

Men 57.6%



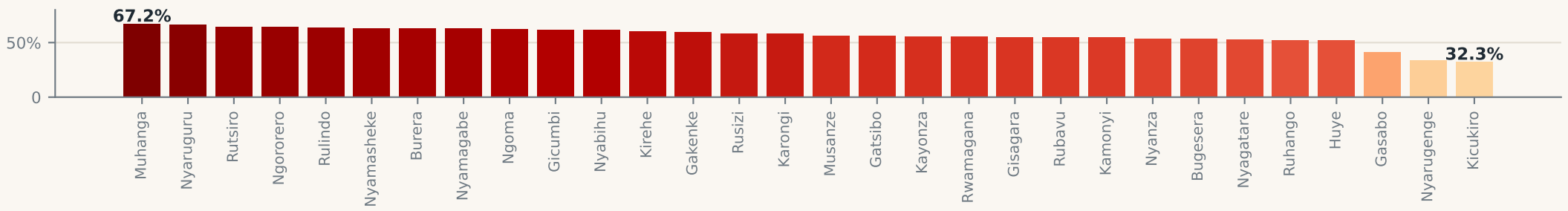
Women 43.7%



Men are 49% of all deaths but 56% of recorded ones, so statistics from registered deaths over-represent men.

4 Where deaths happen outside health facilities

Share of registered deaths in the community, 2025. Rural 61% vs urban 41%. These are the hardest deaths to record.



Source: NISR, Rwanda Vital Statistics Report 2025 (CRVS), Final Tables_CRVS_2025.xlsx. Where tables differ, Table 12 values are used (female 2025 = 43.7%, from Table 12 counts). Projections assume the 2021–25 trend continues (7 data points); 'coincided' does not mean 'caused'. Community = outside a health facility.

Policy: expand verbal autopsies and community death reporting where most deaths happen outside facilities, and close the gap for women.